Royal College of Art
Postgraduate Art and Design

Programme Specification

1. General information

Programme title:	Design Products
Award:	Master's
Qualification Framework level:	Level 7
School/Department or equivalent:	School of Communication & Design
Campus location(s):	Battersea
Total UK credits:	180
Date valid from/to	2026-27

2. Programme Philosophy

Design Products explores new terrain for designing products aiming to evolve new design disciplines and practices. We question 'what is a product?' and the assumption of adding products to uncover critical questioning to inform cutting edge creative practices for designing better futures. Our programme ethos focuses on a range of ideas for exploring these new areas for product design practice. These evolve over time and currently include design subtraction, multi-species design, circularity, questions for action, products delimited, design doing, design justice and decolonising design.

We work in collaboration with industry but also explore new locations and relationships for designing products: the experiences and impacts they generate whether these are design interventions or working with start-ups, governments, or global agencies.
Learning will develop during the programme through terms 1 and 2 via a series of short projects focussed on experimentation and developing a strong and adaptive personal creative process building a portfolio of projects culminating in the development and delivery of an Independent Research Project in term 3.

3. Educational Aims and Learning Outcomes of the Programme

Programme aims

- Explore a series of key future design agendas to uncover new terrain for Designing Products and practices from people to ecosystems;
- Experiment with positioning new and emerging technologies in advanced design practice;
- Facilitate the exploration of new disciplinary directions;
- Critically question and appraise current approaches to Designing Products and the

definition of a product;
- Develop an approach to Design Products which puts the understanding of impact from individual to social, multi-species and global at the heart of design activity.

Learning outcomes

Upon successful completion of the programme, you will be expected to meet the requirements of both the College-wide Learning Outcomes and your programme-specific Learning Outcomes.

College-Wide Learning Outcomes

You should be able to:

- Interrogate and articulate the intentions of your work in relation to the critical and conceptual context of your field(s) of study;
- Independently plan and produce work that is informed by developments at the forefront of your field(s) of study;
- Evaluate and critique the principles and methods of research in your field(s) of study, and apply these principles to your creative, professional and/or scholarly practice;
- Demonstrate originality in how you translate knowledge into practice;
- Communicate your creative, professional and/or scholarly practice to a non-specialist audience;
- Critically reflect on the likely public impact of your creative, professional and/or scholarly practice, and on your responsibilities as a practitioner;
- Define your professional ambitions and identify the challenges involved in meeting them.

Programme-Specific Learning Outcomes

You should be able to:

- Locate your practices in relation to leading ideas in the field;
- Argue for how your own design practice is situated within the forefront of the discipline;
- Articulate the range of ethical issues when developing designs for advanced practice;
- Demonstrate ability to experiment with leading edge making practices;
- Understand, adapt, experiment, and deploy (proposals or) new technological solutions to advanced design challenges;
- Experiment, test and prove technologies across a range of appropriate mediums;
- Demonstrate how your designs impact on the United Nations Sustainability Development Goals;
- Independently manage multiple requirements in delivering advanced practice projects;
- Clearly communicate concepts and creative process using a range of media, techniques and presentation formats.

4. What Will I Learn?

Curriculum Map

<table>
<tr><th colspan="2">Term 1</th><th>Term 2</th><th>Term 3</th></tr>
<tr><td rowspan="2">Locating Practice (15 credits)</td><td rowspan="2">Experimental Design (30 credits)</td><td>Advanced Practice (30 credits)</td><td rowspan="3">Independent Research Project (60 credits)</td></tr>
<tr><td>Grand Challenge (15 credits)</td></tr>
<tr><td colspan="2">AcrossRCA (15 credits)</td><td>Core Skills (15 credits)</td></tr>
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Programme Structure

Unit Title	Term	Credit Value	Core or Elective?
Locating Practice	1	15	Core
Experimental Design	1	30	Core
AcrossRCA (College-wide unit)	1	15	Core
Grand Challenge (School unit)	2	15	Core
Core Skills	2	15	Core
Advanced Practice	2	30	Core
Independent Research Project	3	60	Core

In the first term we help you locate your own practice at the forefront of the design products landscape (*Locating Practice*). This is supported by enhancing research skills and identifying additional technical and intellectual skills to develop new and improved design methods and approaches connecting research and making. *Experimental Design* allows you to expand the range and ambition of your design practice through various forms of experimentation to uncover new skills, methods and ideas. This unit covers a broad spectrum of experimentation from methods to materials, technology, making, manufacturing, futures, social and participatory.

The second term engages with *Advanced Practice* by deepening your own creative methods and application based on programme ethos themes. You will also collaborate with other disciplines in a team-based *Grand Challenge* tackling a major emerging strategic design issue. There are also opportunities to take part in commercially sponsored projects in terms 2 and 3 depending on availability.

AcrossRCA (College-wide unit)

In term 1, you will also participate in AcrossRCA. This unit aims to support you to meet the challenges of a complex, uncertain and changing world by bringing you together to work collaboratively in interdisciplinary teams on a series of themed projects informed by expertise

within and beyond the College. These projects will challenge you to use your intellect and imagination to address key cultural, social, environmental and economic challenges. In doing so, you will develop and reflect on the abilities required to translate knowledge into action, and help demonstrate the contribution that the creative arts can make to our understanding and experience of the world.

Core Skills

The aim of the Core Skills unit is to support you in advancing your academic and professional skills to aid the development of your personal projects at the RCA and beyond in your professional practice and career. The skills covered in this unit reflect those required of a postgraduate student and are adapted by Schools and programmes according to specific disciplinary perspectives and requirements. The Core Skills focus on ways of grounding your work in inclusive, critical, sustainable and ethical approaches, acknowledging and building on the networks of knowledge, practice and communication within which your work sits, and in positioning your practice. Throughout, there is emphasis on how these skills might be situated not only disciplinarily within art, design, architecture, communication and humanities practices, but also within larger contexts, inside and beyond the RCA.

Grand Challenge

I In term 2 you will participate in the Grand Challenge alongside students within and across the School. The aim of this unit is to connect and challenge all students through the introduction of a 'wicked' design problem that requires a cross-disciplinary approach to problem solving which may involve external international partners. This unit and lecture series has been hugely successful in connecting and disrupting disciplines, people, philosophies and approaches to design thinking whilst providing our student body with very unique networking opportunities.

Independent Research Project (IRP)

In the third term you will synthesise learning from terms 1 and 2 by independently developing, managing and delivering a high-resolution Design Products project. The emphasis here is showing how you have brought together skills, learning and design practices from across both terms to design and deliver a project that sits at the forefront of the design products landscape and enables the delivery of a design discourse that argues for the new design space within which it sits.

You will have the opportunity to experiment with the freedom to showcase your learning through the IRP project and related design discourse. Supervisory meetings with staff will take place with the aim of strategically focusing the project trajectory and how it aims to deliver new solutions, innovations or discourse in the field. The final work will include a public exhibition demonstrating your ability to identify and define design opportunities, articulate the significance of a design to stakeholders; and to generate innovative solutions.

There are three Independent Study weeks included in your programme (one per term). During these weeks there will be no scheduled teaching or assessment, and limited access to Technical Services. Self-service will be available for inducted users, and you may independently use computing and technology zones, bench spaces, and the resources store and art shop. These weeks are intended for you to work independently, and technical supervision, fabrication support, or supervision of high-risk activities will not be available.

5. How Will I Learn?

You will learn through a range of teaching typologies which will vary from unit to unit throughout the course, including briefing, critique, exhibition, group tutorial, individual tutorial, lectures, seminars, demonstrations, workshops, peer reviews and independent study. Each unit will comprise of one or more projects which will develop learning up to the assessment point.

We will formally assess learning once in each unit with a formative and summative assessment. A critique or demonstration will be used for either the formative or summative assessment with asynchronous assessment methods, including explanatory short video, desktop display, portfolio, visual presentation, and demonstration used for the other assessment point. The formative assessment will provide you with feedback on the strengths and weaknesses of their work-to-date and recommend strategies for improving learning to enhance the outcome of the summative assessment.

You will submit work in a range of both digital and physical formats depending on the unit project briefs. Examples of submission formats include writing, videos, 2D drawings, sketches and diagrams to test rigs, proof of principle, demonstrators, simulations, prototypes or models.

Your studies are divided into three terms and comprise scheduled staff-led time such as lectures, seminars and tutorials, as well as independent learning. Each term consists of 60 credits which equates to 600 study hours. During each week you should, as a full-time student, expect about 40 study hours. This is made up of two components:

- contact hours (approximately 5-10 per week) which involve timetabled interaction with tutors (for example, in seminars, critiques and tutorials), fostering intellectual exchange by way of clarifying concepts, addressing key questions and cultivating critical thinking;
- the time you dedicate to developing your work independently (in addition to the contact hours) by way of self-directed study which can include activities such as making in the workshops, working in the studio, conducting research or preparing for assessment.

The amount of time you spend in self-directed, independent study will normally increase as you progress to the final term, particularly as you focus on the public exhibition or completion of your work. The precise pattern of contact hours will vary by unit, term and mode of study.

6. Assessment and Feedback

Regulations
The programme is subject to the Academic Regulations of the Royal College of Art (*the regulations are subject to annual updates and amendments*).
Unit assessment

The programme uses a range of assessment methods, including synchronous, such as:

- **Critique** – a group review of work led by one or more academics;
- **Demonstration** – students will perform or demonstrate their design or intervention to prove its qualities in relation to the design brief and learning outcomes.

We will also compliment these with asynchronous assessment methods including:

- **Explanatory short video** - a 3–5-minute video which functions as a stand-alone pitch for the final design proposal;
- **Desktop display** – a display of project material curated to explain the design proposal and learning journey;
- **Portfolio** – a document containing a presented set of unit projects illustrating a series of design proposal and highlighting learning outcomes;
- **Visual presentation** – a stand-alone graphical presentation which can sit alongside a designed product, artifact or intervention that explains the design intent and design discourse;
- **Process Journal** – a detailed record of research, design, development, decision making, process and synthesis used to document the work performed on assigned deliverables and also as a reference to be used to support the development of work across the course;
- **Exhibition** – a public dissemination of the design project used for interactively testing reactions to the proposal.

You can expect a range of formal feedback on your work, including:

- **Tutorials** – individual verbal feedback on a project or stage;
- **Group Tutorials** – shared feedback on work using exemplars and learning from the progress of others;
- **Individual Tutorials** – individual, pastoral focused discussion on topics such as career, goals and experience on the course;
- **Seminars** – thematic investigation of an important Design Products concept where conversation and advice can be applied back to own work;
- **Critiques** – staff will give verbal feedback, question, and critique projects.
- **Demonstrations** – following a demonstration, students will be given succinct feedback on areas to improve and highlights of successful features;
- **Assessment notes** – following assessment project overview notes will be provided to complement verbal and other feedback delivered during the unit to highlight strengths and weaknesses towards meeting the learning objectives;
- **Workshops** – conceptual and applied practical skill sessions where verbal feedback on own learning and adaptation of skills will be given.

Throughout all of the units you will be expected to keep notes of comments and verbal feedback, providing an aid to reflective learning. Informal feedback may also occur in peer reviews and on an ad-hoc basis. Information regarding individual assessments will be included in the unit descriptors available at the beginning of the academic year.

7. What Award Can I Get?

To be awarded an RCA MA degree you need to gain 180 credits at level 7 of the Framework for Higher Education Qualifications (FHEQ). This will involve successfully completing all units.

Exit awards: If you have gained at least 60 credits at Level 7, you may be eligible for the exit award of Postgraduate Certificate. If you have gained at least 120 credits at level 7 of the FHEQ, you may be eligible for the exit award of Postgraduate Diploma.